

DIAGNOSTIC TESTING

This test begins with a scenario that illustrates some criteria that can determine susceptibility to cognitive dissonance.

Cognitive Dissonance Bias Test

Scenario: Suppose that you recently bought a new car, Brand A, Model B. You are very pleased with your purchase. One day, your neighbor finds you in your driveway washing your new car and comments on your new purchase: “Wow, love the new car. I know this model. Did you know that Brand Y, Model Z (Model Z is nearly identical to Model B), was giving away a free navigation system when you bought the car?”

You are initially confused. You were unaware, until now, that Model Z was including a navigation system with purchase of the car. You would have liked to have it. Perhaps, you wonder, was getting Model B a bad decision? You begin to second-guess yourself. After your neighbor leaves, you return to your house.

Question: Your next action is, most likely, which of the following?

- a. You immediately head to your home office and page through the various consumer magazines to determine whether you should have purchased Model B.
- b. You proceed with washing the car and think, “If I had it to do all over again, I may have purchased Model Z. Even though mine doesn’t have a navigation system, I’m still pleased with Model B.”
- c. You contemplate doing some additional research on Model Z. However, you decide not to follow through on the idea. The car was a big, important purchase, and you’ve been so happy with it—the prospect of discovering an error in your purchase leaves you feeling uneasy. Better to just put this thought to rest and continue to enjoy the car.

Test Results Analysis

Answering “c” may indicate a propensity for cognitive dissonance. The next section gives advice on coping with this bias.